



System Critical: The Radical Films of Peter Watkins

The Journey

The Journey

Director: Peter Watkins

Production Companies: Svenska freds- och skiljedomsforeningen, Cinergy Films

Sponsors: Skyworks Charitable Foundation, The Swedish Peace & Arbitration Society

Producer: Peter Watkins

Production Co-ordinators: Catharina Bragee, Lena Ag

Assistant Director/Research/Still Photography:

Klaus W. Becker

Written by: Peter Watkins

Photography: Aribert Weis

Graphics and Animation: Jane Churchill, Joan Churchill

Editors: Peter Watkins, Petra Valier, Manfred Becker, Peter Wintonick

Sound: Uwe Cardaun

Sound Editors: Peter Watkins, Manfred Becker, Tony Reed, Raymond Vermette, Vida Urbonavicius
Sweden-Canada 1987

Parts 1-4: 187 mins

Parts 5-8: 176 mins

Parts 9-12: 182 mins

Parts 13-16: 194 mins

Parts 17-19: 139 mins

Video

Each session will be followed by a discussion led by Benjamin Cook, founder director of LUX, or William Fowler, season co-curator

The Doomsday Clock has been running since 1947. It marks how close unchecked science and technology have brought us to catastrophe, with midnight as the end. When Peter Watkins shot *The Journey* in the mid-1980s the clock stood at three minutes to midnight, pushed there by Cold War tensions between the USA and the Soviet Union. On 27 January this year it was moved to 85 seconds to, the closest it has ever been, citing wars between nuclear-armed states, climate inaction and the uncertainties of AI. This is the moment, in August 2026, that the film returns to the screen at BFI Southbank.

It is usually described in superlatives, epic or monumental, mostly because of its running time of 14.5 hours, and that is probably why it remains one of Watkins' least seen works. Jacob Hovind has compared it to Claude Lanzmann's *Shoah* (1985), and not only for the length but for how both films share an unwillingness to hurry anyone. They let people speak, then make space for what has been said to land in slow, humanistic time.

An important part of the meaning of the film comes from the process of its making. In 1982, with money from Central Television, Watkins began a sequel to *The War Game* (1966), his controversial BBC vision of nuclear apocalypse, which he thought had dated badly. But budget problems quickly killed it. He then approached broadcasters around the world, each to fund a segment in their own territory with local people talking about what they knew of the arms race. Every one of them refused.

What got it moving was the Swedish Peace and Arbitration Society, the oldest peace movement there is, which voted at its centenary congress in 1983 to raise money for the film. Everything after that Watkins built by hand, town by town, raising money with communities in each location and circling the globe three times before it was finished. Only the National Film Board of Canada came in late, with the free use of its post-production facilities. That history is the almost utopian part. It's a film made in living rooms and church halls, paid for by fundraising dinners, after almost every institution that might have backed it said no; an internationalist grassroots project that put ordinary lived experience ahead of mass media to create what Watkins calls a 'global peace film' reflecting on the impacts of the global arms race on the lives of everyday people.

And it does travel. The Outer Hebrides, Mozambique, Japan, Australia, France, Tahiti, the United States, Leningrad (now St Petersburg), and many places in between, to sit with families at kitchen tables and go through photographs of the dead of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, then ask whether they had ever seen anything like it. In the mid-80s many had not. The kitchen table becomes a counter-site for the exchange of information. The families, who in other documentaries would be subjects, take part in making the meaning, speaking back to the film about the effect of what they have been shown and about their own participation. And this is the radical heart of the project, that the camera waits while ordinary people work out, in real time, what the implications are. Sitting with them long enough to notice that at the height of the Cold War a family in Leningrad and a family in Portland are frightened of the same things.

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System Critical: The Radical Films of Peter Watkins

The War Game

Sun 2 Aug 17:45 (+ Samira Ahmed remembers Peter Watkins in an extended conversation with Kevin Brownlow and Kodwo Eshun); Mon 17 Aug 18:20 (+ intro by season co-curator William Fowler)

Peter Watkins: Resistance Isn't Futile

Tue 4 Aug 18:15

Punishment Park

Wed 5 Aug 20:50; Fri 14 Aug 18:15

Peter Watkins and the Playcraft Film Unit

Thu 6 Aug 18:20; Mon 17 Aug 21:10

Privilege

Sat 8 Aug 15:30; Thu 13 Aug 20:45

Culloden + The Making of Culloden

Sun 9 Aug 12:40; Wed 12 Aug 20:40

The Gladiators

aka The Peace Game or Gladiatorena

Sun 9 Aug 15:10; Wed 19 Aug 20:40

Dream of a World

Mon 10 Aug 18:00

Radical Cinema: Past, Present and Future

Histories + Onyeka Igwe in conversation with William Fowler

Thu 13 Aug 18:15

The 70s People 70'ernes folk

Sat 15 Aug 12:20; Mon 24 Aug 20:30

Evening Land Aftenlandet

Sat 15 Aug 20:40; Fri 28 Aug 18:15

Edvard Munch

Sun 16 Aug 14:45; Mon 31 Aug 14:30

The Trap Fällan

Fri 21 Aug 18:20; Wed 26 Aug 20:40

The Journey

Sat 22 Aug (Parts 1-8); Sun 23 Aug (Parts 9-12);

Sat 29 Aug (Parts 13-19)

The Freethinker Fritänkaren

Sun 23 Aug 14:40

The Universal Clock:

The Resistance of Peter Watkins

Tue 25 Aug 18:30

The Media Project

Thu 27 Aug 18:00

La Commune

Sun 30 Aug 12:00

With thanks to

Patrick and Gerard Watkins, Gareth Evans,
Leo Goldsmith, Nina Gosling, Sarah Gosling,
Oliver Groom, Stephen Mercer and Kris Woods

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At times it can be didactic. Watkins hands out facts, that a fortnight of arms spending by the powers of the global north would feed and house the world's population for a year, and every so often he interrupts to tally what has been spent since he last interrupted, and keeps doing it for the whole runtime. Sometimes it feels like a lecture. It also produces the reflexive distance he uses across his many films, exposing the film's own construction, drawing the viewer in and implicating them.

While it repeats itself deliberately, few other films give so honest an account of the painstaking business of building solidarity. This is illustrated in the film when people living near the submarine base at Bangor in Washington State watch the trains carry warheads up from Amarillo through their valley, and start telephoning down the line, town by town, warning the next place along the track, and the next, until there is a chain of small communities holding vigils along the length of the railway. This is resistance at human scale, the slow wiring together of strangers into a movement, over months and years.

Towards the end of the film Watkins starts to make connections between the families who start learning about each other and communicating, and *The Journey* starts to actually build a movement within its own making. While the urgency of the project may have seemed to dissipate in the post-Cold War era, the hands of the doomsday clock speak to the increasing urgency and need for global solidarity movements, and perhaps there is something here we can still learn from. As Tricia Crippen, one of the participants in the film, says: 'It's gotta start with us, and it may end with us if we don't all come to that kind of consciousness.'

Benjamin Cook, bfi.org.uk, 29 July 2026